

Subject: Special class: critical reading of popular press on climate change, March 26.

Dear EPS/ESE 101 climate change scientists,

The class of March 26 will be a special course meeting on critically reading popular press articles about climate change. **This involves a different assignment format, due before that class.**

Before this class, you need to carefully read and analyze your assigned popular press readings, to be sent separately shortly. **Your two assignments:**

(1) Individual assignment: Write a 1-page recommendation (12 pt, single spacing) to the chief editors of the Wall Street Journal and the New York Times, based on your **entire reading assignment**, regarding how they should deal with articles about global warming. Focus on how they should consider scientific accuracy vs factors such as politics & activism. Use examples from the assigned readings when making your points. **Due: Wednesday, 3/26 2 pm, just before class, by Gradescope.**

(2) Group assignment (groups of 2–4 students to be assigned shortly):

(a) Analyze your assigned reading based on the rules of critical reading below. Follow links in your assigned reading and search Google Scholar for relevant scientific literature, carefully evaluating what you find.

(b) Each group will also be assigned one writer of popular-press climate articles. Find several pieces they wrote. What is their position on climate science? Follow the rules below to analyze their credentials; are they climate scientists?

➔ **Based on (2a,b)**, prepare **three** carefully reasoned **PDF slides**, using relevant graphics and in **clear, large font** (see [example slide](#)), with your names on the first slide: **one** summarizing points in your reading assignment you agree with, a **second** slide summarizing those that you feel are not supported by the science, and a **third** slide discussing your assigned author. **Due: Monday, 3/24, 4 pm, 2 days before class, by Gradescope.**

The rules of critical reading:

1. Do not accept any factual statement without verifying it using a Google Scholar search or based on the [latest IPCC report](#).
2. Check the credentials of all authors using Wikipedia and especially Google Scholar. Have they published climate science (as opposed to climate policy/energy) papers in peer-reviewed scientific journals?
3. Identify non-falsifiable statements: these cannot be part of the scientific debate.
4. When a scientific paper is cited as evidence: check where it was published, who the authors were, and whether the paper's findings support the claims made.
5. Specifically for tipping points, consider:
 - a. Is there a positive feedback involved? What is it?
 - b. Is the change irreversible? Why?
 - c. What happened to the system in question in past warm climates?

During class, you will be presenting your slides, & we will discuss how the popular press should cover climate change. The TFs will email your assigned groups & papers shortly.

Presentation guidelines for Class:

- Each of the three slides should be presented **by two people** from the group, **switching mid-way**. The total presentation time per slide is 1 minute.
- All group members should participate in the presentation. Practice your presentation to ensure you deliver your slides according to these time limits, so we have sufficient time for discussion after each presentation.
- We will ask each group to stand in front of the classroom during the presentation, and Eli will switch between the slides on his computer.

To recap:

- Wed 3/24 at 4 pm: group slides for critical reading are due.
- Wed 3/26: Class on critical reading. Two assignments due before class:
 - The Ocean Circulation notebook and essay.
 - Critical reading individual assignment.
- Wednesday, April 2nd: no assignment due before class.

Best, your teaching staff

Email to the students with individual reading assignments,

Subject: Your individual reading assignment for the critical reading class, March 26

Dear EPS/ESE 101 global warming scientists,

Here is your assignment, note that it is due BEFORE class on March 26.

Your group's assignment from

<https://courses.seas.harvard.edu/climate/eli/Courses/EPS101/Sources/Critical-reading/option-4-tipping-points/>

is:

(A) Article 00 (assigned to all students)

(B) Article 05 (assigned to your group only)

When you work on your slides and individual writing assignment, please focus on (B); the first reading (A) is for you to have a wider perspective of the climate tipping point issue as it is covered in the press, and it should be helpful in your individual writing assignment as well.

We recommend using the links rather than the PDFs when possible so you can view the graphics in each article.

Please note the deadlines in Eli's email (below).

Have a great spring break, your teaching staff.